

Critical Questions:

1. When reading the passage, I was reminded of a couple of times where I've employed similar tactics. But sometimes, my initial thoughts turn out to work in the final draft. My question is: When is it okay to skip overanalyzing your thoughts, when might thinking about how you phrase your statements muddle the message?
2. In *Bird by bird*, Lamont states "Not one of them writes elegant first drafts. All right, one of them does, but we do not like her very much." Which got me thinking, I know people can do this, but what makes this possible for some people. Is carefully formatting what you're writing from the get-go a valid option? Or are they just under constant stress, but can just miraculously get through it?

Not even the best, most accredited writers get a final draft of their first try. They create a loose, "shitty" draft first; then with all their thoughts written down, they can improve them. Trying to write down a final draft first thing is futile because everything is going to be overly difficult. Nothing you write will be acceptable, so you must learn how to write down a shitty first draft. Nobody is going to see it after all.

Oftentimes I do find myself trying to create the best thing I can first try. And my process turns out much like Lamott describes: "I'd try to write a lead, but instead I'd write a couple of dreadful sentences, XX them out, try again, XX everything out, and then feel despair and worry settle on my chest like an x-ray apron." (Lamott, 1994, p. 1). I always overthink every little thing, then give up when I inevitably burn myself out after a few sentences. But the bit of advice "You just let this childlike part of you channel whatever voices and visions come through and onto the page. If one of the characters wants to say, 'Well, so what, Mr. Poopy Pants?,' you let her." (Lamott, 1994, p. 1). This is such an amazing way to think about drafting essays. It has a couple of advantages. Number one is that it's easier to revise your half-completed thoughts than it is to create finished thoughts from scratch. And number two is that having several different ideas written down makes it easier to build from them. It's irritating when writing if you reject anything but properly thought-out sentences, so don't! Get down the "shitty" stuff first, then you can refine it later.

Reference

Lamott, A. (1994). *Bird by bird*. Shitty First Drafts.

<https://wrd.as.uky.edu/sites/default/files/1-Shitty%20First%20Drafts.pdf>